

Investigating and Implementing LibreRouter and LibreMesh: Virtualized and Raspberry Pi-Based Mesh Networking

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Abstract—This project investigates LibreRouter and LibreMesh, open-source community networking technologies built on top of OpenWrt. A virtualized OpenWrt environment was developed using VMware Workstation Pro to simulate a four-node routed mesh backbone topology for distributed routing and mesh-network experimentation.

Due to wireless hardware requirements within LibreMesh, OpenWrt with BATMAN-adv was utilized in a virtual environment to emulate and evaluate the same characteristics.

The project will later extend the deployment onto Raspberry Pi hardware platforms for physical mesh networking experimentation and wireless performance evaluation.

I. INTRODUCTION

Community mesh networks provide decentralized communication infrastructure capable of operating independently of centralized Internet Service Providers (ISPs). LibreRouter and LibreMesh were developed to support resilient, community-owned wireless infrastructure using open-source software and commodity hardware.

This project investigates LibreMesh deployment using both virtualized and physical implementations. Primary goals include evaluating routing behavior, deployment complexity, resilience, security considerations, and operational limitations associated with decentralized mesh infrastructure.

In addition to traditional research analysis, this report maintains a reproducible engineering notebook style documenting implementation steps, troubleshooting observations, operational anomalies, and experimental outcomes throughout the project lifecycle.

II. BACKGROUND RESEARCH

A. OpenWrt

OpenWrt is an open-source Linux-based operating system designed for embedded networking devices such as routers and access points. Unlike traditional vendor firmware, OpenWrt provides a writable filesystem, modular package management, and extensive routing customization capabilities.

In addition to embedded hardware deployments, OpenWrt supports x86 virtualized environments, making it suitable for experimental mesh-networking research.

B. LibreMesh

LibreMesh is a framework built on top of OpenWrt that simplifies decentralized mesh-network deployment. The platform automates wireless mesh configuration while supporting routing protocols such as BATMAN-adv and BMX7.

LibreMesh was designed for community-operated networks in which nodes dynamically discover neighboring devices and establish resilient communication paths without centralized infrastructure.

C. LibreRouter

LibreRouter is an open-hardware networking platform developed specifically for community mesh deployments. The platform combines OpenWrt-based firmware with wireless hardware optimized for long-range and community-managed networking applications.

III. LITERATURE REVIEW AND SECURITY ANALYSIS

A. LibreMesh and LibreRouter Deployment Model

LibreMesh is described as a modular framework for creating OpenWrt-based firmware images for wireless mesh nodes. Its goal is to simplify community mesh-network deployment by automating configuration that would otherwise require significant manual OpenWrt networking knowledge [8]. LibreMesh packages support automatic configuration of mesh behavior, while LibreRouter represents a hardware platform designed specifically for community wireless mesh networks [11].

The LibreMesh getting-started documentation recommends hardware with at least 16 MB of flash, 128 MB of RAM, one operational 2.4 GHz radio, and one operational 5 GHz radio [9]. This hardware requirement is significant because VMware virtual machines emulate Ethernet interfaces rather than true IEEE 802.11 wireless radios. As a result, this project could validate BATMAN-adv mesh behavior over virtual Ethernet, but not full RF-based LibreMesh wireless operation.

B. BATMAN-adv Routing Literature

BATMAN-adv is a Linux kernel-based Layer 2 mesh routing protocol. Unlike traditional Layer 3 routing protocols,

BATMAN-adv forwards Ethernet frames and presents participating mesh nodes as if they were connected through a distributed virtual switch [12]. OpenWrt documentation identifies batman-adv as the recommended modern BATMAN implementation for local mesh deployments [13].

BATMAN-adv uses originator messages and distributed topology information to select forwarding paths dynamically. LibreMesh documentation notes that BATMAN-adv periodically sends Originator Messages, with protocol timing affecting convergence speed and control traffic overhead [10]. This aligns with the experimental observations in this project, where node failure, recovery, and reintegration were visible through BATMAN neighbor and originator tables.

C. Community Network Case Studies

Community mesh networks have been studied and deployed in multiple real-world environments. Guifi.net is one of the most widely cited examples of a large-scale community network. Research on Guifi.net describes a crowdsourced network infrastructure operated as a shared commons and supported by community-developed tools and governance processes [16]. Additional experimental analysis of Guifi.net evaluated wireless community mesh behavior and highlighted the operational complexity of hybrid wired and wireless links [17].

Freifunk provides another major example of community mesh networking. The Gluon firmware framework, used by multiple Freifunk communities, is also based on OpenWrt and provides modular firmware generation for wireless mesh nodes [18]. This parallels LibreMesh by showing that community networks often require repeatable firmware-building tools rather than one-off manual router configuration.

NYC Mesh provides a U.S.-based example of volunteer-operated community networking. NYC Mesh uses rooftop wireless links and community-operated infrastructure to provide local broadband access, demonstrating that mesh and community-network concepts can scale beyond laboratory environments [19]. These case studies show that the technical challenges encountered in this project, including addressing, routing, management, and hardware constraints, are also present in real community-network deployments.

D. Security Weaknesses and Operational Risks

Wireless mesh networks introduce several security and operational risks. General wireless mesh security literature identifies attacks involving unauthorized access, routing disruption, malicious node participation, denial-of-service, and traffic interception [20]. Because mesh networks rely on peer participation and distributed forwarding, compromised or misconfigured nodes can affect more than one local link.

OpenWrt package management and update behavior also represent an important security area. OpenWrt security documentation notes that user-space packages can be updated relatively quickly, while kernel and kernel-module fixes may require new releases [14]. This is relevant because BATMAN-adv depends on kernel-module support, and kernel-module

availability affects whether mesh routing can be deployed or patched easily.

The project also encountered package-management weaknesses during implementation. BusyBox wget lacked HTTPS support in the tested OpenWrt image, forcing temporary downgrade from HTTPS to HTTP repository access. This introduced potential risks including repository spoofing, package tampering, and man-in-the-middle attacks. OpenWrt package-signature issues have also appeared in public issue reports, demonstrating that repository trust and update-chain reliability are practical concerns rather than purely theoretical risks [15].

E. Implementation Lessons from Prior Projects

Prior mesh projects demonstrate that deployment repeatability is essential. LibreMesh, Gluon, and OpenWrt ImageBuilder workflows all emphasize firmware generation, package selection, and hardware compatibility. This supports the need for exported configuration files and repeatable setup scripts in this project.

The Commotion project provides another example of decentralized mesh-network tooling and emphasizes usability, configuration management, and security review in mesh-network deployments [21]. These lessons align with this project's experience: successful routing was only one part of the deployment; management access, configuration persistence, file transfer, script compatibility, and reproducible exports were also required to create a usable mesh-network testbed.

F. Summary of Identified Weaknesses

The literature review and project implementation identified several major weakness categories:

- Hardware dependency on supported wireless radios for full LibreMesh deployment
- Package-management and update-chain risks in embedded router systems
- Kernel-module dependency for BATMAN-adv functionality
- Potential routing disruption from malicious or misconfigured mesh nodes
- Management-plane instability caused by cloned router identities and DHCP conflicts
- IPv6 duplicate-address behavior after virtual-machine cloning
- Limited realism of virtual Ethernet compared to physical wireless RF environments
- Need for repeatable configuration export and deployment documentation

IV. VIRTUALIZED OPENWRT DEPLOYMENT

A. Virtualization Environment

VMware Workstation Pro 17 was selected as the virtualization platform for the initial implementation phase. Virtualization provided rapid deployment, rollback capability through snapshots, reproducible experimentation, and simplified troubleshooting prior to deployment on physical Raspberry Pi hardware.

B. OpenWrt Image Preparation

The OpenWrt x86_64 ext4 combined image was downloaded from the official OpenWrt release repository. Since VMware does not natively boot raw IMG files efficiently, the OpenWrt disk image was converted into VMware VMDK format prior to deployment.

C. Virtual Machine Configuration

A custom virtual machine configuration was selected in VMware Workstation Pro to allow manual control over networking interfaces and storage configuration.

TABLE I
INITIAL OPENWRT VM CONFIGURATION

Setting	Value
Guest OS	Other Linux 5.x 64-bit
vCPUs	1
Memory	256 MB
Primary Disk	OpenWrt VMDK
Network Adapter 1	NAT
Network Adapter 2	Host-only

D. Network Interface Design

Two virtual network adapters were configured for each virtual router node:

- NAT adapter for WAN connectivity and package installation
- Host-only adapter for internal mesh backbone communication

This architecture allowed the virtual environment to simulate isolated routed mesh connectivity while preserving Internet access for package installation and updates.

E. Initial Boot Validation

The OpenWrt virtual machine booted successfully after the VMDK disk image was attached to the VMware virtual SCSI controller.

During startup, OpenWrt initialized both virtual Ethernet interfaces successfully:

```
eth0 NIC Link is Up
eth1 NIC Link is Up
```

The successful initialization confirmed that VMware virtual networking devices were correctly recognized by the OpenWrt kernel.

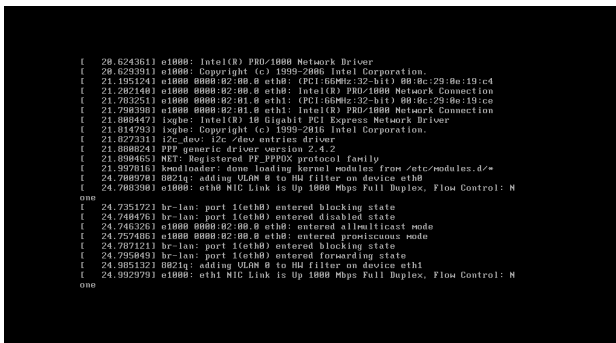


Fig. 1. Successful OpenWrt boot and interface initialization.

V. NETWORK TROUBLESHOOTING AND RECOVERY

A. Initial Connectivity Failure

Initial deployment attempts failed to provide Internet connectivity.

Observed symptoms included:

- Missing default routes
- Failed DNS resolution
- Inability to ping external IP addresses
- DHCP inconsistencies

Example failure:

```
ping -c 4 8.8.8.8
Network unreachable
```

Investigation revealed that VMware host-only networking was unintentionally acting as the WAN DHCP source, creating interface ambiguity and routing instability.

Observed VMware virtual networks included:

- VMnet1: 192.168.61.0/24
- VMnet8: 192.168.111.0/24

B. Controlled Simplification Strategy

To isolate the networking issue, the second adapter was temporarily removed and the deployment simplified to a single NAT interface.

After simplification, the OpenWrt node successfully received:

- DHCP assignment
- Default gateway
- External DNS access

Working configuration:

```
default via 192.168.111.2 dev eth0
```

Successful validation tests included:

```
ping -c 4 8.8.8.8
ping -c 4 google.com
```

All tests completed successfully with zero packet loss.

C. Package Management Failure Analysis

Package management operations initially failed during APK repository access.

Observed errors included:

```
wget exited with error 1
unexpected end of file
```

Further investigation revealed that BusyBox wget lacked HTTPS support:

```
wget https://downloads.openwrt.org/
HTTPS support not compiled in.
```

This explained repeated failures retrieving APK repository metadata over HTTPS and forced temporary downgrade of repository transport from HTTPS to HTTP in order to restore package functionality.

Potential security implications included:

- Man-in-the-middle attacks
- Package tampering
- Repository spoofing
- Supply-chain compromise

D. Temporary Package Recovery

HTTPS functionality was partially restored by manually transferring APK packages into the virtual machine and installing them locally:

```
apk add --allow-untrusted ./*.apk
```

Repository transport was later temporarily modified from HTTPS to HTTP to restore repository index access.

After modification:

```
apk update
```

successfully completed.

Core administrative packages were then installed successfully:

```
apk add nano
apk add vim
apk add curl
apk add tcpdump
apk add htop
apk add bash
apk add luci
```

VI. LUCI WEB INTERFACE DEPLOYMENT

After installation of LuCI, the OpenWrt web interface was initially inaccessible through:

```
http://192.168.1.1
```

Diagnostic analysis using:

```
netstat -tlnp
```

confirmed that the web server was actively listening on ports 80 and 443:

```
0.0.0.0:80 LISTEN
0.0.0.0:443 LISTEN
```

Further analysis revealed that the Windows host system could directly access only the VMware NAT interface rather than the internal OpenWrt LAN bridge. As a result, the LuCI interface became accessible using:

```
http://192.168.111.130
```

rather than the internal bridge address.

This demonstrated the distinction between:

- Internal OpenWrt LAN addressing
- Externally reachable VMware NAT addressing
- Hypervisor network segmentation behavior

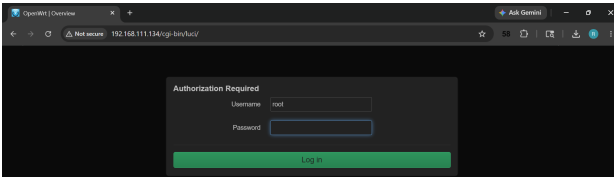


Fig. 2. Accessible LuCI web management login page

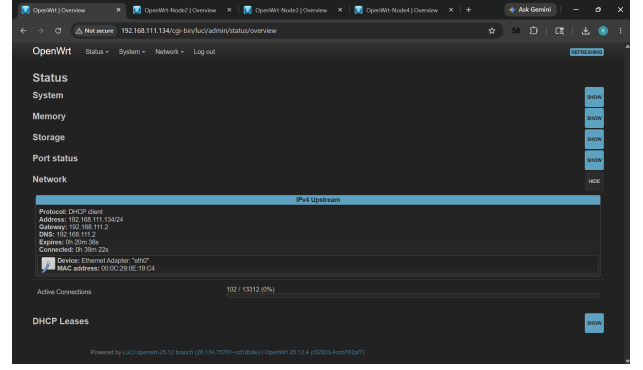


Fig. 3. Accessible LuCI web management interface through VMware NAT networking.

VII. MULTI-NODE MESH BACKBONE CONSTRUCTION

A. Dual-Interface Mesh Backbone

After establishing a stable baseline, a second virtual adapter was reintroduced using VMware host-only networking.

The second interface was assigned as a dedicated mesh backbone network:

```
uci set network.mesh=interface
uci set network.mesh.proto='static'
uci set network.mesh.device='eth1'
uci set network.mesh.ipaddr='10.10.10.1'
uci set network.mesh.netmask='255.255.255.0'
uci commit network
/etc/init.d/network restart
```

Resulting topology:

TABLE II
DUAL-INTERFACE OPENWRT TOPOLOGY

Interface	Address	Purpose
eth0	192.168.111.x	VMware NAT / WAN
eth1	10.10.10.x	Internal mesh backbone

Routing verification confirmed correct segmentation:

```
default via 192.168.111.2 dev eth0
10.10.10.0/24 dev eth1
```

```
root@OpenWrt:~# ip route
default via 192.168.111.2 dev eth0 src 192.168.111.134
10.10.10.0/24 dev eth1 scope link src 10.10.10.1
192.168.1.0/24 dev eth0 scope link src 192.168.1.1
192.168.111.0/24 dev eth0 scope link src 192.168.111.134
root@OpenWrt:~#
```

Fig. 4. Validated OpenWrt Node 1 routing table showing WAN and mesh backbone separation.

B. VM Cloning Strategy

Instead of reinstalling OpenWrt repeatedly, a stable “golden image” virtual machine was cloned using VMware full-clone functionality.

Resulting nodes included:

- OpenWrt-Node1
- OpenWrt-Node2
- OpenWrt-Node3

- OpenWrt-Node4
- Each node received:
- Unique hostname
 - Unique mesh backbone address
 - VMware-generated MAC address

C. Four-Node Mesh Backbone Validation

The resulting mesh backbone addressing scheme included:

TABLE III
FOUR-NODE MESH BACKBONE ADDRESSING

Node	Mesh Address
OpenWrt-Node1	10.10.10.1
OpenWrt-Node2	10.10.10.2
OpenWrt-Node3	10.10.10.3
OpenWrt-Node4	10.10.10.4

Connectivity testing was performed between all nodes using ICMP echo requests.

Successful bidirectional communication was verified between all nodes with:

- Zero packet loss
- Stable latency
- Successful route propagation

The successful validation demonstrated:

- Stable Layer 2 adjacency
- Functional Layer 3 routing
- Operational VMware host-only backbone networking
- Successful multi-node OpenWrt virtualization

```

root@OpenWrt-Node4:~# ping -c 2 10.10.10.1
PING 10.10.10.1 (10.10.10.1) 56(84) bytes of data:
64 bytes from 10.10.10.1: icmp_seq=1 ttl=64 time=2.18 ms
64 bytes from 10.10.10.1: icmp_seq=2 ttl=64 time=1.33 ms

--- 10.10.10.1 ping statistics ---
2 packets transmitted, 2 received, 0% packet loss, time 1004ms
rtt min/avg/max/mdev = 1.334/1.755/2.176/0.421 ms
root@OpenWrt-Node4:~# ping -c 2 10.10.10.2
PING 10.10.10.2 (10.10.10.2) 56(84) bytes of data:
64 bytes from 10.10.10.2: icmp_seq=1 ttl=64 time=2.23 ms
64 bytes from 10.10.10.2: icmp_seq=2 ttl=64 time=4.05 ms

--- 10.10.10.2 ping statistics ---
2 packets transmitted, 2 received, 0% packet loss, time 1003ms
rtt min/avg/max/mdev = 2.234/3.542/4.051/1.300 ms
root@OpenWrt-Node4:~# ping -c 2 10.10.10.3
PING 10.10.10.3 (10.10.10.3) 56(84) bytes of data:
64 bytes from 10.10.10.3: icmp_seq=1 ttl=64 time=1.92 ms
64 bytes from 10.10.10.3: icmp_seq=2 ttl=64 time=1.40 ms

--- 10.10.10.3 ping statistics ---
2 packets transmitted, 2 received, 0% packet loss, time 1003ms
rtt min/avg/max/mdev = 1.400/1.700/1.921/0.220 ms
root@OpenWrt-Node4:~#

```

Fig. 5. Successful four-node mesh backbone connectivity validation.

D. Sequential Startup and DHCP Convergence

Initial simultaneous startup of cloned nodes produced temporary WAN IP duplication behavior within the VMware NAT network.

Multiple nodes briefly inherited identical DHCP leases from previous cloned states.

This behavior was mitigated by sequential node startup. Sequential startup allowed VMware DHCP services to converge properly and assign unique WAN addresses based on MAC address differentiation.

Final WAN assignments stabilized as:

- Node1: 192.168.111.134
- Node2: 192.168.111.136
- Node3: 192.168.111.137
- Node4: 192.168.111.138

This demonstrated:

- DHCP lease convergence behavior
- Temporary ARP instability during cloned startup
- Virtualization timing dependencies
- Successful MAC-based lease differentiation

E. IPv6 Duplicate Address Detection Behavior

During sequential startup of cloned nodes, OpenWrt repeatedly reported IPv6 duplicate address detection warnings:

IPv6 duplicate address detected

Despite repeated IPv6 duplicate detection events:

- IPv4 routing remained stable
- Mesh backbone communication remained operational
- Node-to-node connectivity was unaffected

This behavior represents an important operational consideration for cloned embedded router deployments and virtualized distributed networking systems.

```

[ 17.533917] procd: - init -
Please press Enter to activate this console.
[ 17.759256] kmodloader: loading kernel modules from /etc/modules.d/*
[ 17.790805] urngd: v1.0.2 started.
[ 17.851278] e1000: Intel(R) PRO/1000 Network Driver
[ 17.859459] e1000: Copyright (c) 1999-2006 Intel Corporation.
[ 18.560079] e1000 0000:02:00:00:00:00 eth0: (PCI:66MHz:32-bit) 00:0c:29:0a:60:7a
[ 18.560535] e1000 0000:02:00:00:00:00 eth0: Intel(R) PRO/1000 Network Connection
[ 19.141060] e1000 0000:02:00:00:00:00 eth1: (PCI:66MHz:32-bit) 00:0c:29:0a:60:80
[ 19.147917] e1000 0000:02:00:00:00:00 eth1: Intel(R) PRO/1000 Network Connection
[ 19.165779] ixgbe: Intel(R) 10 Gigabit PCI Express Network Driver
[ 19.172232] ixgbe: Copyright (c) 1999-2016 Intel Corporation.
[ 19.185750] i2c_dev: i2c /dev entries driver
[ 19.237386] PPP generic driver version 2.4.2
[ 19.244786] NET: Registered PF_PPPOX protocol family
[ 19.364798] kmodloader: done loading kernel modules from /etc/modules.d/*
[ 21.753403] 8021q: adding VLAN 0 to HW filter on device eth0
[ 21.764090] e1000: eth0 NIC Link is Up 1000 Mbps Full Duplex, Flow Control: N
one
[ 22.005832] 8021q: adding VLAN 0 to HW filter on device eth1
[ 22.013022] e1000: eth1 NIC Link is Up 1000 Mbps Full Duplex, Flow Control: N
one
[ 22.006777] IPv6: eth0: IPv6 duplicate address fdbb:a609:d40c::1 used by 00:0
c:29:0a:19:c4 detected!

```

Fig. 6. Observed IPv6 duplicate address detection during sequential startup of cloned OpenWrt nodes.

VIII. BATMAN-ADV MESH ROUTING DEPLOYMENT

A. BATMAN-adv Installation

After the successful construction of the four-node OpenWrt backbone topology, the BATMAN-adv routing protocol was deployed to provide dynamic Layer 2 mesh routing functionality.

The following packages were installed on all nodes:

```
apk add kmod-batman-adv batctl luci-proto-batman-adv
```

Successful installation loaded the BATMAN kernel module dynamically:

```
lsmod | grep batman
```

The BATMAN mesh interface was manually initialized:

```
modprobe batman-adv
ip link add name bat0 type batadv
ip link set up dev bat0
```

The dedicated mesh transport interface was attached to BATMAN:

```
batctl meshif bat0 if add eth1
```

```
root@OpenWrt:~# modprobe batman-adv
root@OpenWrt:~# ip link add name bat0 type batadv
root@OpenWrt:~# ip link set up dev bat0
[ 4339.498563] 8021q: adding VLAN 0 to HW filter on device bat0
root@OpenWrt:~# ip link show bat0
4: bat0: <BROADCAST,MULTICAST,UP,LOWER_UP> mtu 1500 qdisc noqueue state UNKNOWN
qlen 1000
    link/ether 8e:7f:35:59:1c:ce brd ff:ff:ff:ff:ff:ff
root@OpenWrt:~# _
```

Fig. 7. Successful initialization of the BATMAN-adv virtual mesh interface.

B. Dynamic Neighbor Discovery

BATMAN dynamically discovered neighboring routers using:

```
batctl meshif bat0 n
```

Originator propagation tables were observed using:

```
batctl meshif bat0 o
```

```
root@OpenWrt-Node3:~# batctl meshif bat0 n
[B.A.T.M.A.N. adv 2025.4-openwrt-4, MainIF/MAC: eth1/00:0c:29:0a:68:00 (bat0/5e:
da:e2:a5:06:84 BATMAN_IU)]
IF Neighbor last-seen
eth1 00:0c:29:a7:71:c8 0.040s
eth1 00:0c:29:0e:19:ce 0.200s
root@OpenWrt-Node3:~# batctl meshif bat0 o
[B.A.T.M.A.N. adv 2025.4-openwrt-4, MainIF/MAC: eth1/00:0c:29:0a:68:00 (bat0/5e:
da:e2:a5:06:84 BATMAN_IU)]
Originator last-seen (s/255) Nexthop [outgoingIF]
00:0c:29:a7:71:c8 0.300s ( 82) 00:0c:29:0e:19:ce [ eth1 ]
* 00:0c:29:a7:71:c8 0.300s ( 84) 00:0c:29:a7:71:c8 [ eth1 ]
00:0c:29:0e:19:ce 0.020s ( 82) 00:0c:29:a7:71:c8 [ eth1 ]
* 00:0c:29:0e:19:ce 0.020s ( 93) 00:0c:29:0e:19:ce [ eth1 ]
root@OpenWrt-Node3:~# _
```

Fig. 8. BATMAN-adv originator routing tables dynamically populated across the mesh.

C. Four-Node Mesh Convergence

All four OpenWrt nodes successfully joined the distributed BATMAN mesh.

The resulting deployment demonstrated:

- Autonomous neighbor discovery
- Dynamic route propagation
- Persistent distributed convergence
- Self-healing mesh behavior

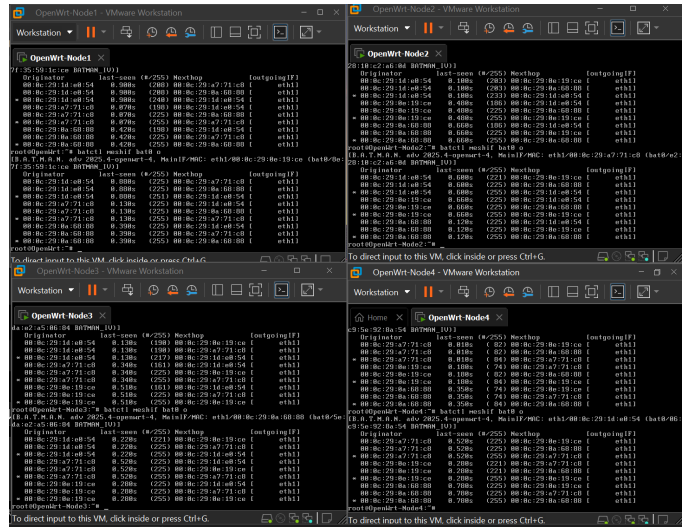


Fig. 9. Stable four-node BATMAN-adv mesh topology before failure testing.

D. Node Failure and Reconvergence

One node was intentionally powered off during operation to evaluate mesh resilience behavior.

Immediately after failure:

- Neighbor tables updated dynamically
- Stale originators were removed
- Remaining nodes maintained connectivity

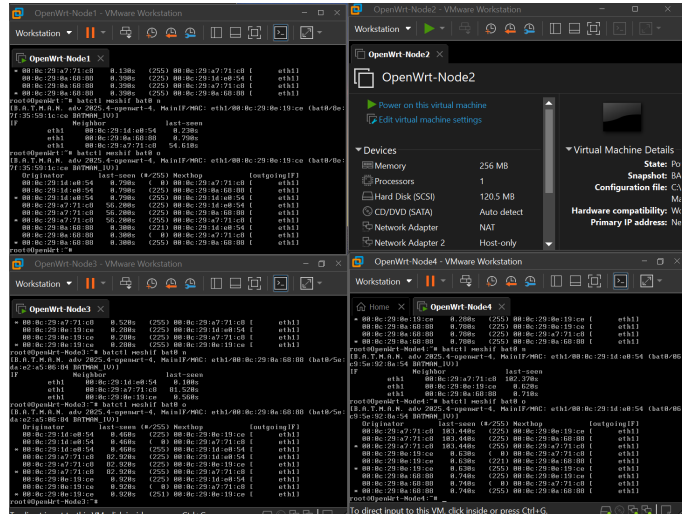


Fig. 10. BATMAN topology immediately following intentional node failure.

E. Node Reintegration

After reboot, the failed node automatically rejoined the distributed mesh without manual reconfiguration.

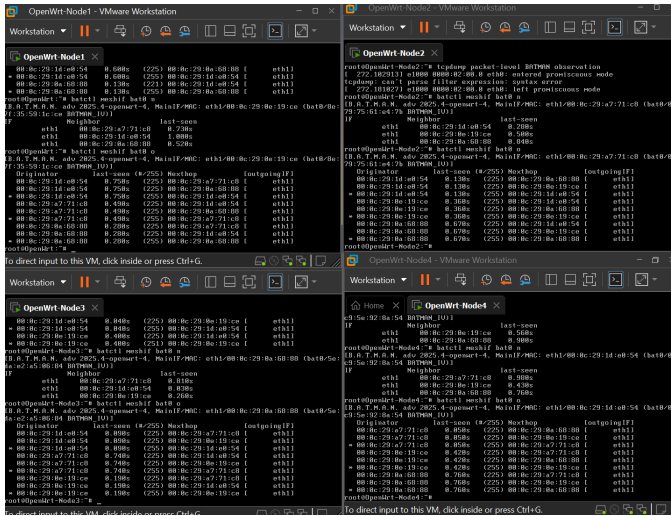


Fig. 11. Automatic BATMAN mesh reconvergence after node restoration.

F. Persistent BATMAN Configuration

Persistent deployment was implemented using OpenWrt UCI configuration:

```
uci set network.bat0=interface
uci set network.bat0.proto='batadv'
uci set network.bat0.routing_algo='BATMAN_IV'

uci set network.mesh_bat=interface
uci set network.mesh_bat.proto='batadv_hardif'
uci set network.mesh_bat.master='bat0'
uci set network.mesh_bat.device='eth1'

uci commit network
```

After reboot, all nodes automatically:

- Recreated bat0
- Reattached eth1
- Rediscovered neighbors
- Rejoined the mesh

G. BATMAN Native Ping and Traceroute

BATMAN-native connectivity was validated using:

```
batctl meshif bat0 ping <neighbor MAC>
```

Traceroute functionality was validated using:

```
batctl meshif bat0 traceroute <neighbor MAC>
```

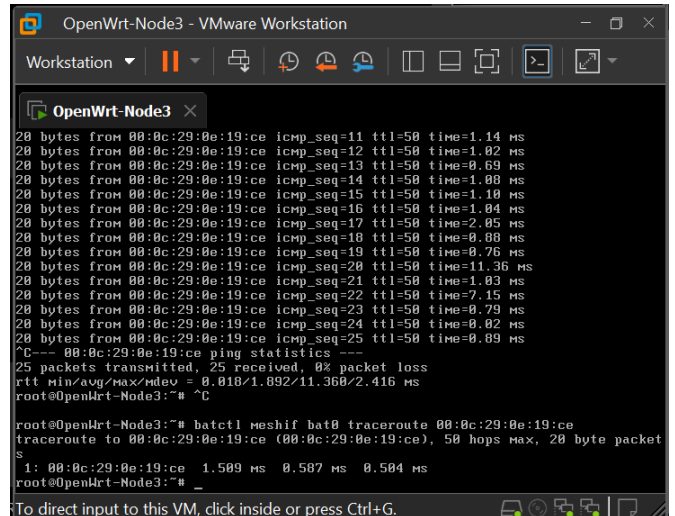


Fig. 12. BATMAN-native traceroute across the distributed mesh topology.

H. MTU Optimization and Fragmentation Analysis

BATMAN generated warnings indicating insufficient MTU allocation on the transport interface.

Initial configuration:

- eth1 MTU: 1500
- bat0 MTU: 1500

The transport interface MTU was increased experimentally:

```
ip link set dev eth1 mtu 1532
```

Following optimization:

- Neighbor discovery remained stable
- BATMAN forwarding persisted
- Packet loss remained zero

Interestingly, bat0 continued operating at MTU 1500 while eth1 operated at MTU 1532.

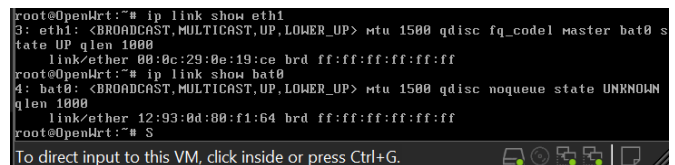


Fig. 13. Initial BATMAN deployment with insufficient MTU allocation.

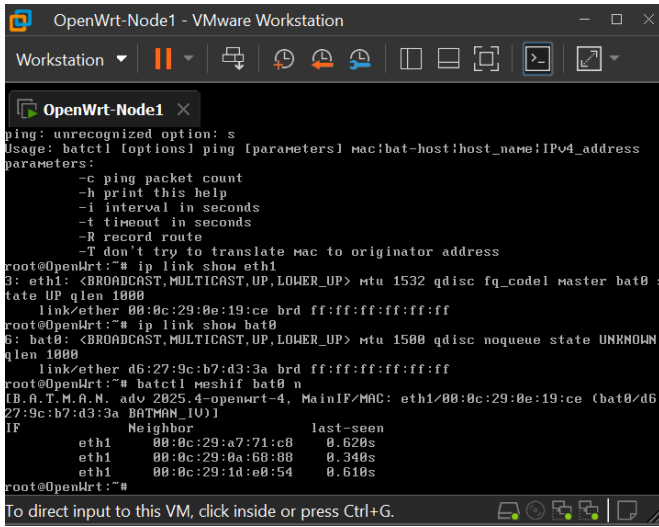


Fig. 14. Stable BATMAN operation following MTU optimization.

I. Management-Plane Addressing Issues

During virtual-machine cloning, multiple nodes temporarily inherited overlapping management-plane identities.

Observed effects included:

- Duplicate DHCP assignments
- Ambiguous LuCI access
- IPv6 duplicate-address warnings

Despite management-plane ambiguity, the BATMAN forwarding plane remained fully operational.

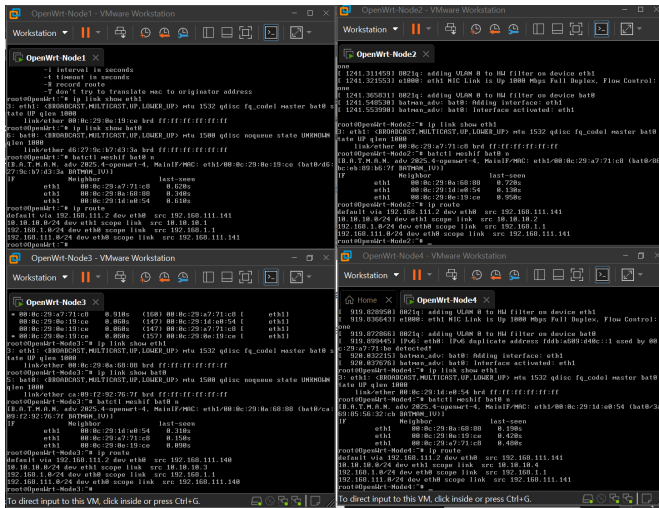


Fig. 15. Management-plane addressing conflicts during cloned OpenWrt deployment.

IX. LIBREMESH FIRMWARE AND WIRELESS HARDWARE REQUIREMENTS

The LibreMesh project provides prebuilt OpenWrt-based firmware images designed specifically for decentralized wireless mesh deployments.

Installation procedures and firmware selection guidance were obtained from the official LibreMesh documentation and firmware selector platform.

LibreMesh installation generally requires:

- OpenWrt-supported hardware
- At least 16 MB flash storage
- At least 128 MB RAM
- One operational 2.4 GHz wireless radio
- One operational 5 GHz wireless radio

The dual-radio recommendation exists because LibreMesh commonly separates:

- Client-access traffic
- Mesh-backhaul traffic

Typical deployments utilize:

- 2.4 GHz radios for local client access and extended range
- 5 GHz radios for higher-throughput mesh backhaul links

LibreMesh firmware may be obtained using:

- LibreMesh Firmware Selector
- Precompiled firmware archives
- Custom OpenWrt ImageBuilder compilation

The project initially investigated whether full LibreMesh wireless meshing could be reproduced entirely inside VMware virtualization.

However, VMware virtual network adapters emulate Ethernet devices rather than physical IEEE 802.11 wireless radios.

As a result, VMware virtual adapters do not provide:

- True wireless PHY behavior
- RF channel negotiation
- Wireless beaconing
- 802.11s mesh operation
- Ad-hoc wireless functionality
- Monitor-mode radio capabilities

Although BATMAN-adv operated successfully over virtual Ethernet interfaces, this represented a Layer 2 routed mesh simulation rather than a true wireless LibreMesh deployment.

The virtualized environment therefore successfully validated:

- Distributed BATMAN routing behavior
- Dynamic neighbor discovery
- Autonomous route propagation
- Persistent distributed convergence

However, full LibreMesh wireless operation will require physical wireless hardware during the Raspberry Pi deployment phase.

X. CONFIGURATION EXPORT AND DEPLOYMENT REPRODUCIBILITY

To satisfy reproducibility requirements, configuration artifacts and operational mesh-state information were exported directly from all OpenWrt nodes.

The exported artifacts included:

- Persistent OpenWrt UCI configuration files
- BATMAN neighbor tables
- BATMAN originator tables

- Routing tables
- Interface-state information
- Installed package inventories

A reusable export automation script was developed to simplify artifact extraction across all nodes.

The script automatically:

- Collected configuration files
- Captured BATMAN operational state
- Archived deployment artifacts
- Generated compressed export bundles

The resulting deployment archives were extracted remotely from the OpenWrt nodes using SSH and SCP.

A. Automated Configuration Export Script

The following script was deployed on all OpenWrt nodes:

```
#!/bin/sh

NODE_NAME="$(cat /proc/sys/kernel/hostname)"
OUTDIR="/root/config-export"
ARCHIVE="/root/${NODE_NAME}-config-export.tar.gz"

mkdir -p "$OUTDIR"

cp /etc/config/network \
"$OUTDIR/network-${NODE_NAME}"

cp /etc/config/system \
"$OUTDIR/system-${NODE_NAME}"

cp /etc/config/firewall \
"$OUTDIR/firewall-${NODE_NAME}"

cp /etc/config/dhcp \
"$OUTDIR/dhcp-${NODE_NAME}"

batctl meshif bat0 if > \
"$OUTDIR/batman-if-${NODE_NAME}.txt"

batctl meshif bat0 n > \
"$OUTDIR/batman-neighbors-${NODE_NAME}.txt"

batctl meshif bat0 o > \
"$OUTDIR/batman-originators-${NODE_NAME}.txt"

ip addr > \
"$OUTDIR/ip-addr-${NODE_NAME}.txt"

ip route > \
"$OUTDIR/ip-route-${NODE_NAME}.txt"

apk list --installed > \
"$OUTDIR/packages-${NODE_NAME}.txt"

tar -czf "$ARCHIVE" \
-C /root config-export
```

B. Windows and Linux Script Compatibility Issues

During deployment automation, shell scripts transferred from Windows systems to OpenWrt routers initially failed with:

```
-ash: /root/export-config.sh: not found
```

Investigation revealed that the script contained Windows CRLF line endings rather than Linux LF line endings.

This caused BusyBox ash to misinterpret the script interpreter line:

```
#!/bin/sh^M
```

The issue was corrected using:

```
sed -i 's/\r$//' /root/export-config.sh
```

This represented an important interoperability consideration between Windows administrative systems and embedded Linux networking environments.

C. SSH and SCP Artifact Extraction

Configuration archives were remotely extracted from OpenWrt nodes using SCP over SSH.

Modern Windows SCP implementations attempted to default to SFTP mode, which was unsupported by the lightweight OpenWrt Dropbear deployment.

Observed error:

```
subsystem request failed on channel 0
scp: Connection closed
```

Successful extraction required forcing legacy SCP protocol mode:

```
scp -O root@192.168.111.x:/root/archive.tar.gz .
```

This demonstrated another operational limitation common within lightweight embedded Linux distributions where full SFTP subsystems are often omitted to conserve storage space and memory resources.

XI. GIT-BASED COLLABORATIVE CONFIGURATION MANAGEMENT

To improve reproducibility, collaboration, and long-term configuration management, the project artifacts were integrated into a Git-based version-control workflow using GitHub.

The repository centralized:

- LaTeX report source files
- Figures and screenshots
- OpenWrt configuration exports
- BATMAN operational logs
- Deployment scripts
- Supporting documentation

This approach allowed multiple project participants to:

- Retrieve synchronized project files
- Contribute modifications collaboratively
- Maintain deployment history
- Track configuration revisions
- Restore previous project states if necessary

A. Repository Initialization

A new local Git repository was initialized within the project directory:

```
git init
```

A .gitignore file was created to exclude temporary LaTeX compilation artifacts including:

```
*.aux
*.log
*.out
*.toc
*.synctex.gz
```

Project files were staged and committed locally:

```
git add .
git commit -m "Initial LibreMesh project upload"
```

The local repository was then connected to a remote GitHub repository:

```
git remote add origin \
https://github.com/<user>/<repo>.git
```

The repository was uploaded using:

```
git branch -M main
git push -u origin main
```

B. Repository Structure

The resulting repository structure organized project artifacts into separate directories:

```
EC3730-Pro/
|-archive/
|-report/
|-virtual machines/
|-EC3730_Final_Project.pdf
|-README.md
```

This structure separated:

- Documentation
- Deployment scripts
- Configuration archives
- Experimental artifacts

C. Collaborative Workflow

Additional project participants could retrieve the repository using:

```
git clone \
https://github.com/<user>/<repo>.git
```

Once cloned locally, collaborators could synchronize project updates using:

```
git pull
```

Modified files could then be uploaded back to the shared repository using:

```
git add .
git commit -m "Describe changes"
git push
```

This created a distributed collaborative workflow allowing all participants to maintain synchronized copies of the deployment environment and report documentation.

D. Version-Control Benefits

Git-based version control provided several operational advantages during experimentation:

- Distributed backup of project artifacts
- Historical tracking of configuration changes
- Simplified collaboration between participants
- Recovery from accidental file modification
- Improved reproducibility of deployment procedures

The integration of Git-based workflow management significantly improved the maintainability and reproducibility of the overall mesh-network deployment project.

XII. FUTURE RASPBERRY PI DEPLOYMENT

The final implementation stage will migrate the virtualized mesh environment onto Raspberry Pi hardware devices running OpenWrt and LibreMesh.

The Raspberry Pi deployment will evaluate:

- Physical wireless mesh formation
- Real-world throughput and latency
- Hardware limitations
- Deployment obstacles
- Inter-group node interoperability

XIII. UNRESOLVED OPERATIONAL CHALLENGES AND FUTURE INVESTIGATION

Although the distributed BATMAN-adv mesh deployment operated successfully overall, several operational inconsistencies and unresolved behaviors were identified during experimentation.

These issues represent valuable future investigation areas for both virtualized and physical mesh deployments.

A. Persistent VMware DHCP Address Duplication

Although earlier sequential startup procedures improved DHCP convergence behavior, VMware NAT services still occasionally assigned identical WAN-side addresses to multiple cloned OpenWrt nodes.

Example observed behavior included:

- Multiple nodes simultaneously assigned 192.168.111.141
- Ambiguous SSH access
- Non-deterministic LuCI management behavior
- Administrative-plane collisions

Although sequential startup reduced the frequency of collisions, duplicate assignments still occasionally reappeared during extended experimentation.

The issue appeared isolated to VMware NAT-side DHCP behavior and did not affect BATMAN forwarding functionality operating on the dedicated mesh backbone interface.

This behavior represents an important virtualization-management limitation requiring further investigation.

B. IPv6 Duplicate Address Detection Events

OpenWrt repeatedly reported IPv6 duplicate address detection warnings during sequential startup and node cloning operations:

```
IPv6 duplicate address detected
```

Despite repeated warnings:

- IPv4 routing remained operational
- BATMAN mesh convergence persisted
- Node-to-node communication remained stable

The project did not fully investigate:

- IPv6 address autoconfiguration behavior
- Duplicate IPv6 neighbor advertisements
- IPv6 interactions with BATMAN-adv
- Potential virtualization-layer MAC/address reuse

Future work should evaluate whether disabling IPv6 entirely or implementing static IPv6 addressing would improve deployment stability.

C. Management-Plane and Forwarding-Plane Separation

The project revealed significant architectural separation between:

- Administrative management-plane behavior
- BATMAN distributed forwarding behavior

Even during severe management-plane inconsistencies:

- BATMAN neighbor discovery remained stable
- Originator propagation continued
- Distributed forwarding functionality persisted

This behavior further confirmed the resilience of BATMAN forwarding despite administrative-plane instability.

D. Lightweight Embedded Linux Limitations

Several OpenWrt operational limitations were identified during experimentation:

- Missing HTTPS support in BusyBox wget
- Missing SFTP subsystem support in Dropbear
- Minimal shell-tool availability
- CRLF/LF shell-script compatibility issues

These limitations complicated:

- Package installation
- Secure artifact transfer
- Deployment automation
- Remote administration

While expected for lightweight embedded environments, these limitations introduced significant operational overhead during deployment and experimentation.

E. Incomplete Multi-Hop Routing Validation

Although the BATMAN mesh operated successfully across all four nodes, the VMware host-only topology allowed all routers to remain directly adjacent at Layer 2.

As a result, the deployment did not fully validate:

- True multi-hop relay behavior
- Intermediate-node forwarding dependency
- Mesh partition recovery
- Indirect route optimization

Future work should intentionally isolate subsets of nodes to force multi-hop forwarding paths and evaluate true relay-based mesh behavior.

F. Future WireGuard-Based Inter-Mesh Federation

Future experimentation may connect independent BATMAN mesh deployments between project groups using encrypted WireGuard overlay tunnels.

Potential future architecture:

- Independent local BATMAN clusters
- WireGuard encrypted Internet overlays
- Distributed inter-group route propagation
- Geographically separated mesh federation

This would allow evaluation of:

- Distributed mesh scalability
- Internet-based overlay transport
- Secure inter-cluster communication
- Hybrid mesh-overlay architectures

XIV. CONCLUSION

This project successfully implemented a persistent four-node distributed OpenWrt mesh-routing laboratory environment using VMware virtualization and BATMAN-adv.

The completed deployment demonstrated:

- Successful OpenWrt virtualization
- Stable multi-node routed mesh backbone construction
- Autonomous BATMAN neighbor discovery
- Dynamic distributed originator propagation
- Persistent mesh deployment through UCI configuration
- Autonomous reconvergence after node failure
- BATMAN-native ping and traceroute functionality
- MTU optimization and fragmentation analysis
- Packet-level mesh observation using tcpdump
- Identification of virtualization and management-plane edge cases

The project evolved significantly beyond initial router virtualization objectives and ultimately produced a functional distributed autonomous mesh-routing research platform suitable for continued LibreMesh experimentation and future Raspberry Pi deployment.

The completed environment represents a robust foundation for continued experimentation with decentralized community-networking infrastructure using LibreMesh and BATMAN-adv.

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AI USAGE DISCLOSURE

Artificial intelligence tools were used during portions of this project to assist with:

- Technical troubleshooting
- Linux and OpenWrt command analysis
- BATMAN-adv deployment guidance
- VMware networking diagnostics
- LaTeX report formatting
- Documentation organization and editing

AI-assisted guidance was used interactively throughout deployment and experimentation; however, all configuration, implementation, troubleshooting, validation, testing, and analysis were performed directly by the project team.

The report content was reviewed, modified, and validated manually to ensure technical accuracy and consistency with observed system behavior.

OpenAI ChatGPT was used as an engineering-assistance and documentation-support tool during the project lifecycle.

APPENDIX A

EXPORTED CONFIGURATION AND OPERATIONAL ARTIFACTS

The following exported artifacts were generated and archived from each OpenWrt node:

- network-nodeX
- system-nodeX
- firewall-nodeX
- dhcp-nodeX
- batman-if-nodeX.txt
- batman-neighbors-nodeX.txt
- batman-originators-nodeX.txt
- ip-addr-nodeX.txt
- ip-route-nodeX.txt
- packages-nodeX.txt

These artifacts provide reproducible deployment state information and operational validation for the completed distributed BATMAN-adv mesh environment.